Chapter 1: A Great Love Story?

“The Taj Mahal rises above the banks of the river like a solitary tear suspended on the cheek of time.” - Rabindranath Tagore, Bengali Nobel Laureate Poet

“Rahul had wondered how someone could love their beloved so much that their dedication to them became one of the wonders of the world.” - Faraaz Kazi, modern novelist

“Marble, I perceive, covers a multitude of sins.” - Aldous Huxley, author of *Brave New World*

At its heart, the Taj Mahal - the greatest triumph of Persian and Mughal architecture, a widely recognized modern wonder of the world, and the prize of India - is a story about love and devotion. Its designer, the Mughal Emperor Shah Jahan, created it as the tomb and memorial to his beloved wife Mumtaz Mahal. The soaring marble dome, towers reaching to the heavens, and lush formal gardens all sing out testimony to his love for her. Or so the story goes.

The Taj Mahal’s purpose as a mausoleum, and an incredible one at that, has long led many to credit its origins to the fairy-tale love of Shah Jahan and Mumtaz Mahal, a guiding myth told for the millions of visitors annually. As Rabindranath Tagore described so beautifully, in this tale it is a "solitary tear suspended on the cheek of time," an attempt to commemorate a feeling for a person in the grandest manner possible. Perhaps not surprisingly, parts of this overarching story have a basis in fact, but much of it includes later innovation, fabrication, and imagination.